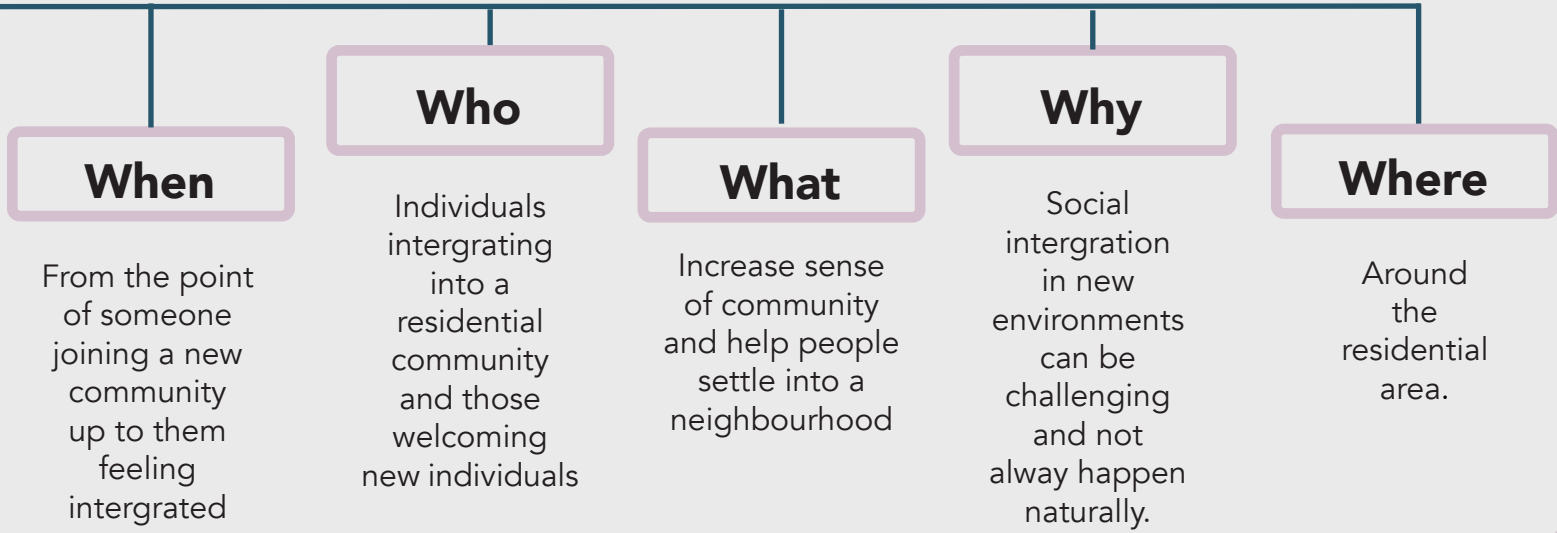


The image is a composite graphic. The background is an aerial photograph of a city skyline at dusk or dawn. The sky is a deep blue, and the city lights are visible. A large, semi-transparent orange rectangle covers the right half of the image. The text is overlaid on this orange area.

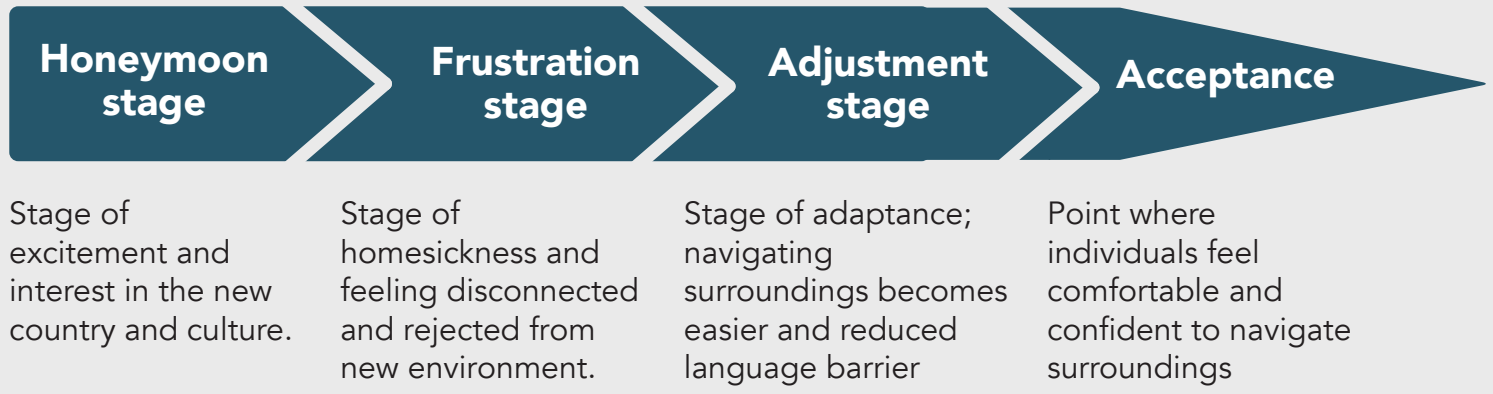
URBAN SPACES

**FUN INTENDED
HCDE 2025**

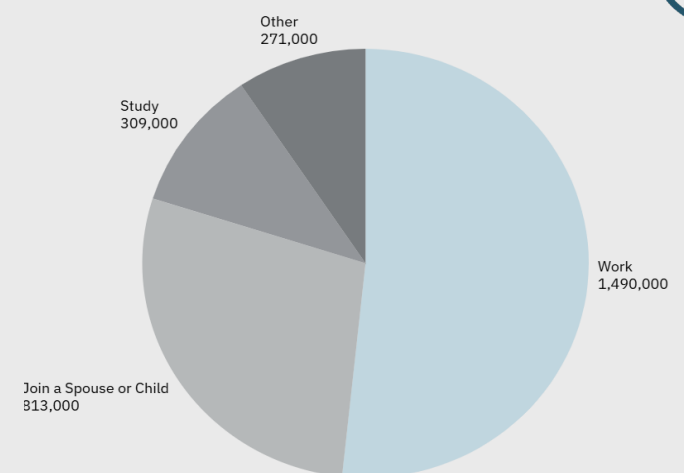
Context



The 4 Stages of Culture [1]



A pie chart to show the reasons for migration for EU nationals to the UK in 2015 [2]



The problem

Moving to a new city especially internationally, is widely recognized as one of **life's most stressful events**. Beyond adjusting to a new physical space, individuals must overcome the **social barriers** within a new community. During this period individuals may experience **culture shock** and **social isolation**. **Language barriers, unfamiliar customs, and a lack of immediate social support** can make it difficult to build meaningful connections.

57% of Brits ranked moving house as the **'most stressful event of their life'** [3]

From 2019 to 2023, net migration increased by [4] **74%**

The number of internationals increases, yet many still struggle to adjust to local customs.

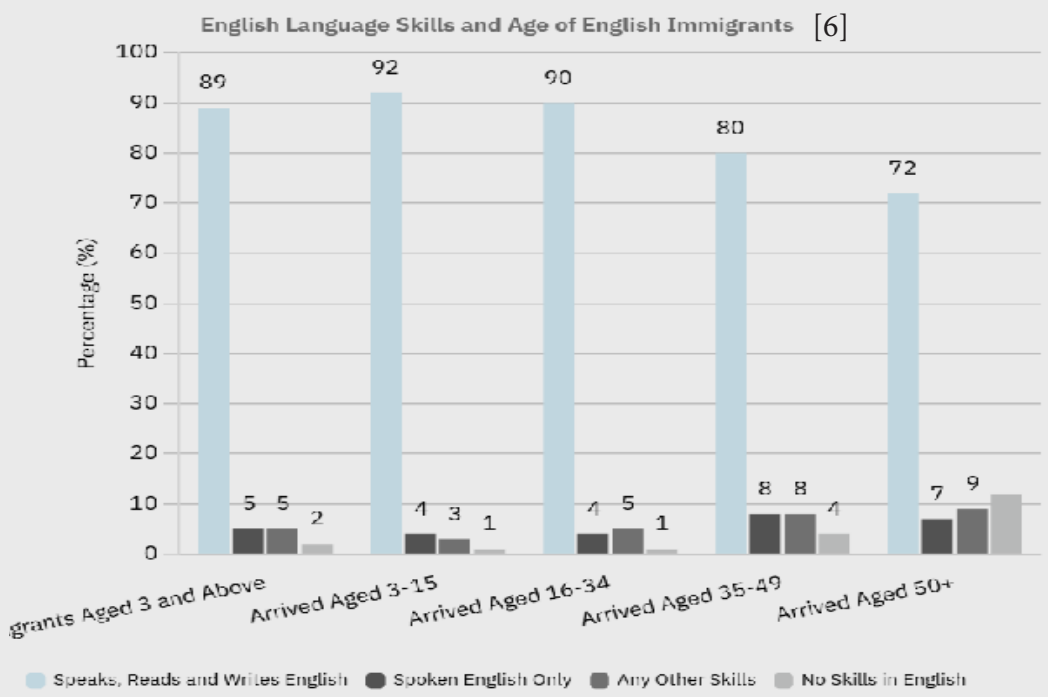
53% feel that they do **not belong** in their neighbourhood [5]

What is play? [7]

Play consists of a mix of elements

- fun
- voluntary
- intrinsically motivated
- imaginative or creative

Intrinsic motivation means that the outcome is not the focus of the activity but rather on the activity itself. This means that it is a state of mind in which **failure is permitted** and **mistakes are learning opportunities**.



Insightful Conversation
We spoke with a Chinese parent who **felt uncertain** about her child's schooling due to a lack of support and guidance. This conversation highlighted how many migrant parents **struggle to navigate unfamiliar systems alone**, sparking our focus on creating **better community connections** and accessible support for newcomers.

Research Process

An overview of our research process to go more in-depth on people in the UK. At this stage, our goal is to fully identify the struggles that international newcomers go through while settling in the UK.

Observations STEP 1



Observation in different urban areas, ranging from a quiet neighbourhood to tourist spots.

Aims and approach:

- Observe the public's behaviour outside, finding out what worries they have with the facilities.
- Look at public/urban spaces, and take pictures + notes of all behaviour to make into insights

Pictures during taking observations:



Survey STEP 2



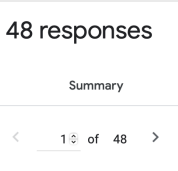
After observations, conducting a survey can help us solidify any problems we think the public have in urban spaces.

Aims and approach:

- Conduct a survey with questions related to foreigners' worries on their experiences of living in the UK
- Send out surveys in family group chats, facebook group and analyse the data to form insights.



The survey results after conducting it:



The parent group chat that the survey was sent to

Personas and Journey mapping STEP 5



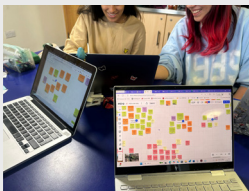
Create personas on our target audiences, so that we can cater to them when creating our product.

Aims:

- To identify key challengers that newcomers may face when joining a new society.
- Creating three different personalities that fit into our target audience, and creating different journeys for each.

Approach:

- 1. Group the insights that we found in the previous steps to give our personas different goals.
- 2. Give them all different personalities and lives, so they have different reactions to entering a new environment.



Us working on grouping insights

Interviews STEP 3

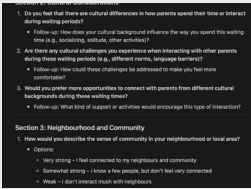


After selecting our target group, we interviewed people we knew that fell in the category of "international".

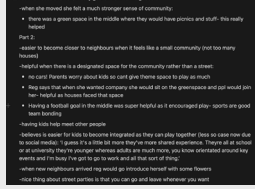
Aims and approach:

- Ask questions to gain more precise insights on integration in new communities and observational conflicts.
- Interview each person with premade interview scripts, and use quotes as the basis of our insights.

The premade questions to be asked at the interview:



An example of one of the transcripts:



Context mapping and Affinity diagram STEP 4

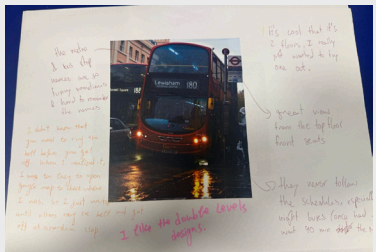
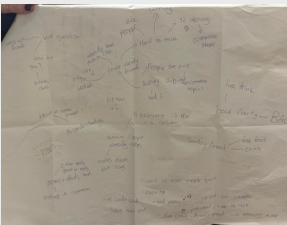


Speaking to a group of international students about their current life in the UK.

Aims and approach:

- To know the culture shocks that foreigners face when living in the UK, and how to smoothen their journey.
- Give them activities and pictures to write on/about, and use their thoughts to make insights.

Pictures from the context mapping session:



Insights and Opportunities STEP 6



- Using all of the insights we had gained from before, we combined similar ones into main insights.
- After this, we made them into opportunities, creating HMW's out of them.
- We combined the key aspects of each HMW to make a big, main, conclusive HMW.



Grouping all the different insights, observations and thoughts together



Discussing our best HMW's and got aspects of our other favourites to make our final HMW

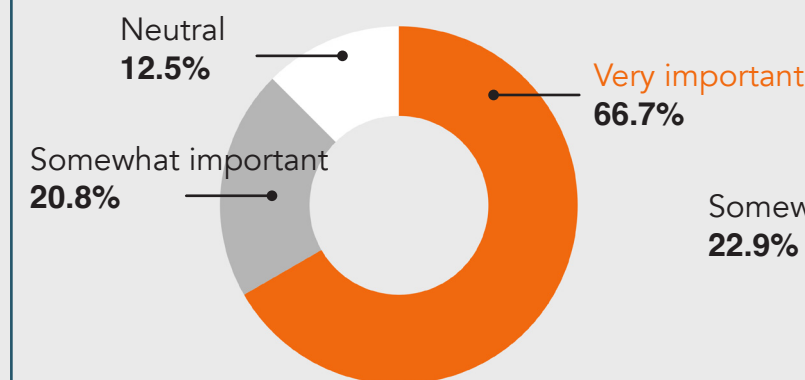
Observations and Survey

Our first step of the research process was to find out what worries the public had at already existing public spaces. So, after doing observations, and conducting a survey, we gained insights to help choose our target group.

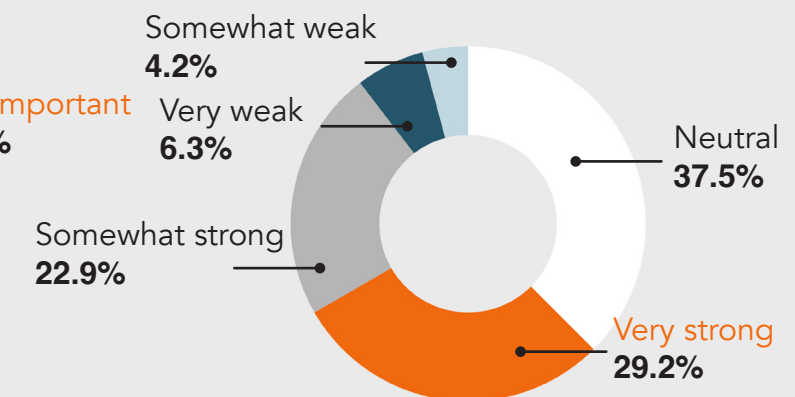
Survey

We conducted a survey asking people from different neighbourhoods, on their experience with their neighbours, regarding cultural differences, children and difficulties. **We gathered responses from 48 people.**

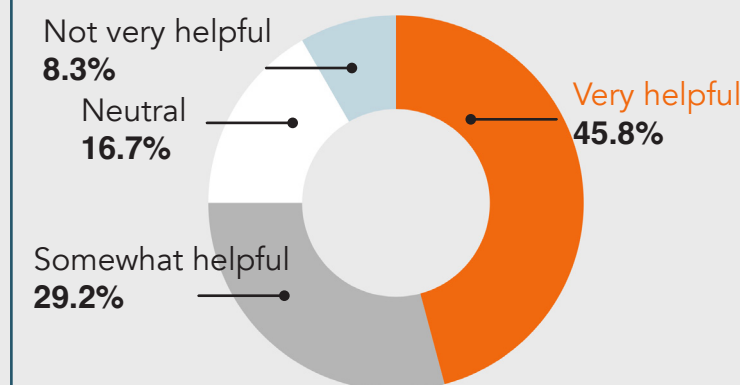
How important is it for you to maintain your cultural practices and values while raising your children in an urban environment?



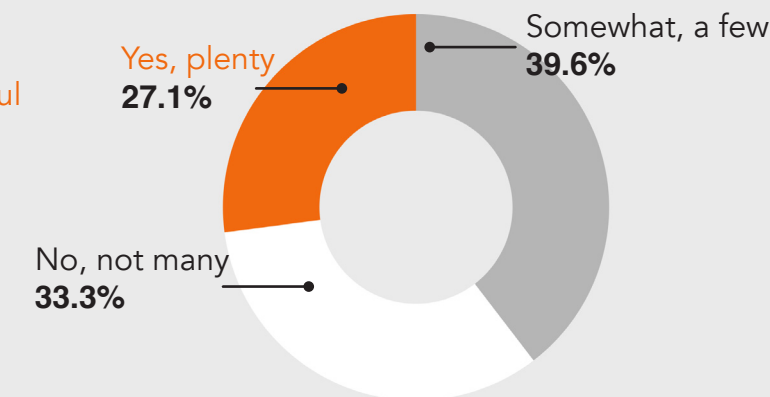
How would you describe your overall sense of community in your residential area?



How helpful has knowing your neighbours been in your day-to-day life?



Do you feel like there are enough opportunities to meet and interact with your neighbours in your current residential area?



Insights and summary

- When reviewing the survey results, we found out that most of the people who said that their cultural practices weren't being maintained in their environment were also the ones that thought their sense of community was not strong enough. This could indicate that **cultural differences may be a barrier to being integrated into a neighbourhood.**
- Although many people described their community as close-knit, everyone still wished for an even **stronger sense of connection.**
- During observations, we found out that **proximity** is a great way for relationships to form: "by just knowing your neighbours, running into them, having little conversations"



Interviews

We conducted interviews to gain first hand perspectives from newcomers about their experiences integrating into a new community. By speaking directly with individuals, we aimed to understand their challenges, needs, and emotions in a way that observations alone couldn't capture.

Heather Langlais



Heather and her husband, a Canadian couple in their 60s, moved to the UK for work, initially settling in Hammersmith before relocating to Ealing in summer 2023.

Online Connections

Their street's WhatsApp group helped them **borrow items** and find furniture, with these **small acts of trust** making them feel **more part of the community**.

Organized Events

They **enjoyed local events** like the summer street party and Christmas carolling, which created a **welcoming atmosphere for neighbors to meet**.

However, most interactions **didn't lead to deeper connections**. Heather adjusted to less small talk and more reserved social norms, realizing that **"You don't invade the British."**

Safety Concerns

Shortly after moving, Heather got off at the wrong bus stop and, **unfamiliar with the area**, walked through a dark park, **feeling unsafe**. She asked her husband to meet her, recalling,

"seeing shadows of men, thinking is that my husband or is that a serial killer?"



Insights and Oppotunities:

Insight: Small acts of **community support**, like borrowing items or helping neighbors, **build trust** and make newcomers feel included.

Opportunity: Encourage **community-driven initiatives** that foster trust through informal, everyday interactions.

Regina Segers



Social & Cultural Differences

Casual interactions in England felt more **reserved**, making it harder to connect. While sitting on the green encouraged spontaneous conversations, **deeper engagement was less common**.

Language & Communication Barriers

One-on-one conversations were easier, but **noisy spaces** like pubs made **communication difficult**, increasing social barriers. Quieter, structured settings could help newcomers feel more comfortable.

Challenges in Building Friendships

"It took me two years before I made proper English friends." Forming deeper connections was a **slow process**, showing that integration takes time and long-term support is needed.

Community Support & Events

Small acts of kindness helped build relationships, and low-commitment events like street parties made socializing easier without pressure.

Urban & Social Barriers

Busy city life made it harder to connect, as people were often focused on work and routines. More **flexible, low-effort interactions**

could help bridge the gap for newcomers.

In urban areas, people are always busy-work, life, everything-so it's harder to form connections



Insights and Oppotunities:

Insight: Noisy, structured environments like pubs **heightened social barriers**, making communication difficult for newcomers.

Opportunity: Develop **quieter, inclusive social settings** where newcomers feel comfortable engaging.

Walker Family



The Walker family moved from California to London for a job opportunity in the tech industry. While excited for the transition, they faced **significant challenges**, particularly in social integration.

Social Disconnection

The Walker family moved to London for work but found it **difficult to establish a sense of belonging**. While their children adapted through school, the parents struggled to build **meaningful connections**.

Barriers to Integration

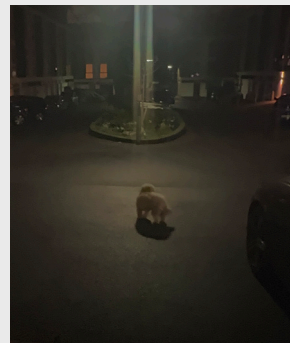
Unfamiliarity with the area made it hard to find **social opportunities**. While locals were polite, casual interactions were rare, making it difficult to form friendships naturally.

Urban Safety Concerns

Some public areas felt **unwelcoming and unsafe**, with poor lighting, minimal security, and a **lack of inviting spaces**, making it difficult for newcomers to feel comfortable engaging with others. Additionally, **unpredictable weather** further restricted access to outdoor spaces, limiting opportunities for casual, everyday social interactions.

Navigating Local Systems

Adjusting to a new city meant **learning unfamiliar systems** like transport, healthcare, and community resources. Without guidance, this added to their **sense of disconnect** and uncertainty.



Insights and Oppotunities:

Insight: **Unwelcoming public spaces**, poor lighting, and unpredictable weather **discouraged social engagement**.

Opportunity: Improve urban design with **inviting, well-lit, and weather-protected** public areas that encourage **casual interactions**.

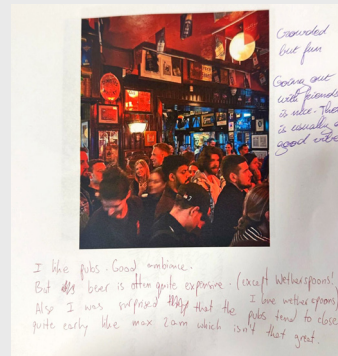
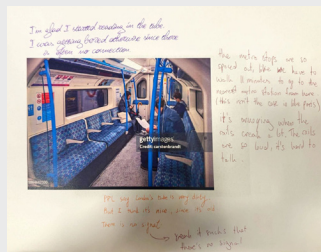
Context mapping & Affinity diagram

1. Image Association

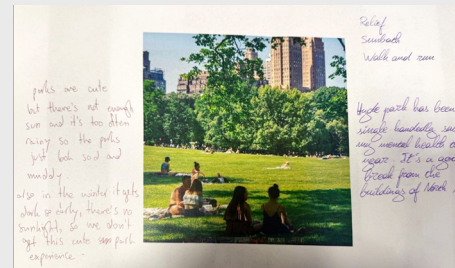
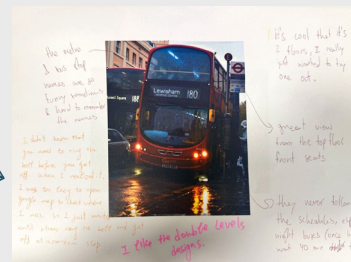
Our first activity involved minmapping, where participants wrote their **thoughts around preselected photos** of urban spaces across London. These responses ranged from lighthearted observations to more serious critiques. The goal was to gain a **general understanding** of people's likes, dislikes, and immediate **reactions to different environments**. This helped us identify what aspects of urban spaces work well and which ones may create barriers, guiding our design decisions.



"The rails are so loud,
it's hard to talk"



"I didn't know you had to ring the bell before you got off"



"Hyde park is single handedly saving my mental health this year"

Emotional Responses to Space

People had **strong, immediate reactions** to different environments, reinforcing how **subtle design choices** - such as lighting, seating arrangements, greenery, and layout - can **deeply impact feelings** of comfort, safety, and engagement. This highlights the **importance of sensory and spatial design** in shaping how people experience and interact with public spaces.

2. Fresher's Experience

Our second activity involved **conversations with participants**, where they **reflected** on their first week of university and Freshers' events. We discussed what **helped** them meet new people **successfully** and what **challenges they faced** in forming connections.



Shallow Interactions

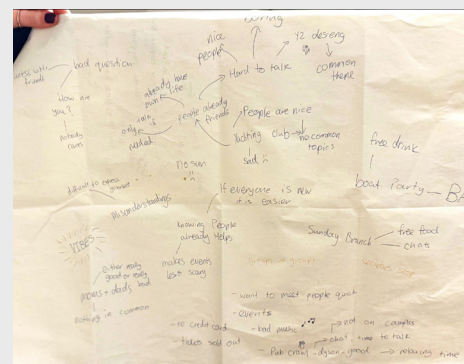
Many Freshers' Week interactions were **one-time conversations** that didn't lead to lasting friendships.

Limited Lasting Connections

Participants were not friends with most people they met that week, suggesting that initial social events often **lack depth or follow-up opportunities.**

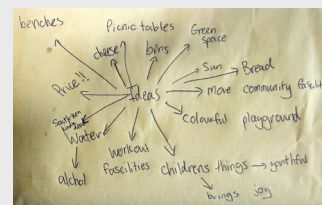
Shared Interests Matter

Activities that centered around **common interests were the most effective** for forming meaningful connections.



3. Final thoughts

After conducting both activities we asked the participants for their **final thoughts**. From this we made a small mindmap with ideas they had of **what would ease the transition** for others.



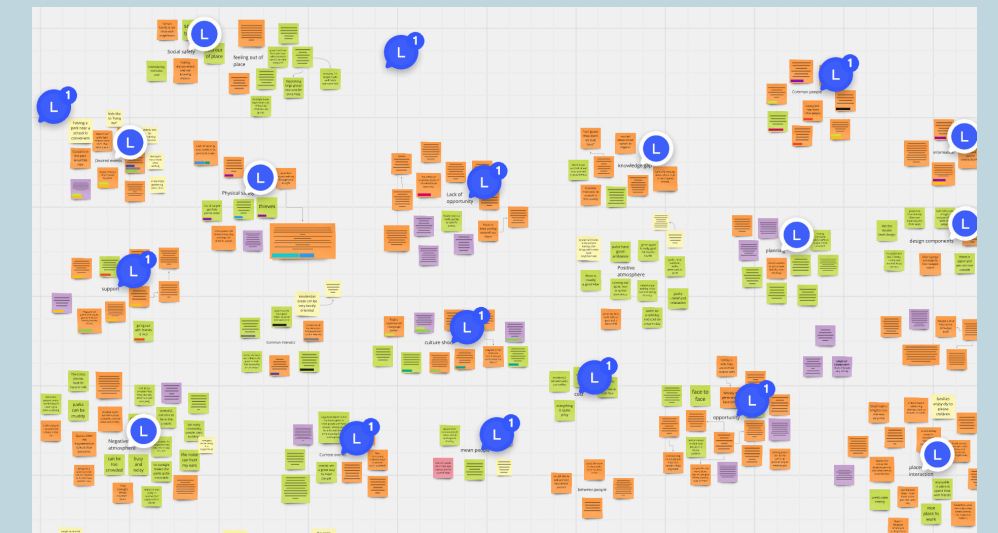
Insights

These activities reinforces some previous findings as well as introducing a new perspective. One theme that came up again was the **frustration** caused by **shallow interactions** and one-time conversations. This recurring pain point suggests that the social norm of shallow small talk is a common catalyst for experiences of culture shock.

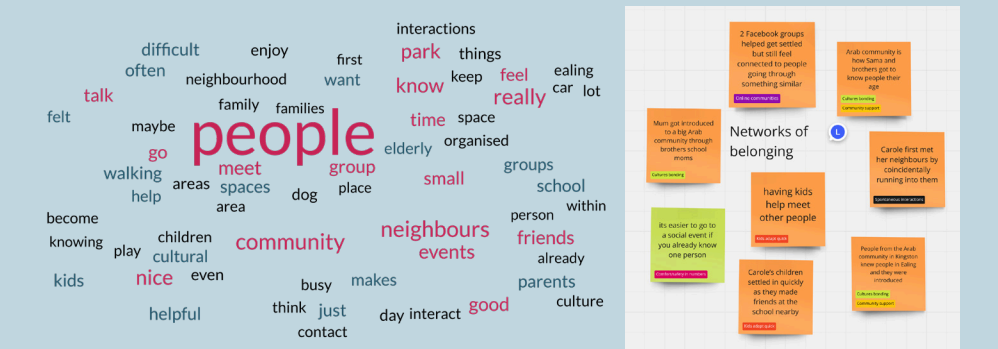
Some of the new findings included the influence of existing emotional responses to public spaces on the overall experience of a place or event.

Through context mapping the experience of international students we got a better idea of the process of settling into a new place. This was the last of our data collection, and so we moved on to organising and analysing it all.

Affinity diagram



Once we finished with our data collection, we created individual **data points** and organised them **into groups**. From these groups we used **thematic coding** to **spot connections** and **overarching themes**. From all the information we created a word cloud as a different way to see the common themes. This helped lead us towards our HMW.



Personas and Journey Mapping

This personas and journey mapping exercise helped us identify key challenges and needs of newcomers in urban spaces. By analysing their experiences, we gained insights to design more inclusive environments that foster connection and belonging.

Attentive Amir



Age 0 100

Introverted Extroverted

English ☒ ☒

Needs: Family-friendly spaces for parents and kids to connect. Low-pressure social interactions without language barriers.

Pain Points:

Avoids planned community events due to overwhelm and language barriers.	Feels disconnected and unsure how to integrate.	Kids struggle to make friends without shared activities.
---	---	--

Goals: He wants his children to make friends and feel at home while engaging with the community in everyday life rather than relying on organized events. He also hopes to feel comfortable in public spaces despite limited language skills.

Spontaneous Sofia



Age 0 100

Introverted Extroverted

English ☒ ☒

Needs: Inviting public spaces that spark spontaneous interactions, playful ways to experience local culture, and experiences that create a true sense of belonging.

Pain Points:

Loves meeting new people but struggles to form deeper connections.	Feels like an outsider despite wanting to be involved.	She finds it hard to naturally join social circles: groups already feel established.
--	--	--

Goals: She wants to connect with locals in a natural, fun way while discovering hidden gems that make her feel at home. She hopes to immerse herself in the community without needing a specific reason to be there.

Working Wei



Age 0 100

Introverted Extroverted

English ☒ ☒

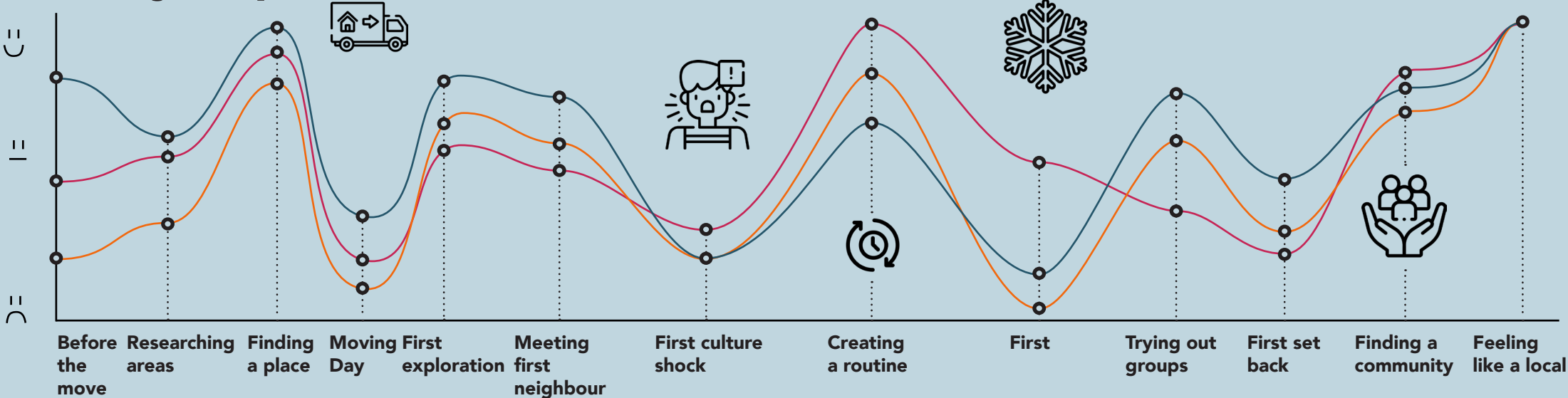
Needs: Public spaces that foster familiarity, repeated interactions and opportunities to build deeper connections beyond small talk.

Pain Points:

Feels most social spaces are catered to families or students not her.	Feels stuck in a cycle of shallow, one-time interactions.	Struggles to make lasting friendships unrelated to work.
---	---	--

Goals: She hopes to build meaningful relationships that go beyond networking. She wants a sense of routine in a community space where she can regularly see familiar faces, engage in shared experiences, and feel a natural sense of belonging.

Journey map



Persona Summary

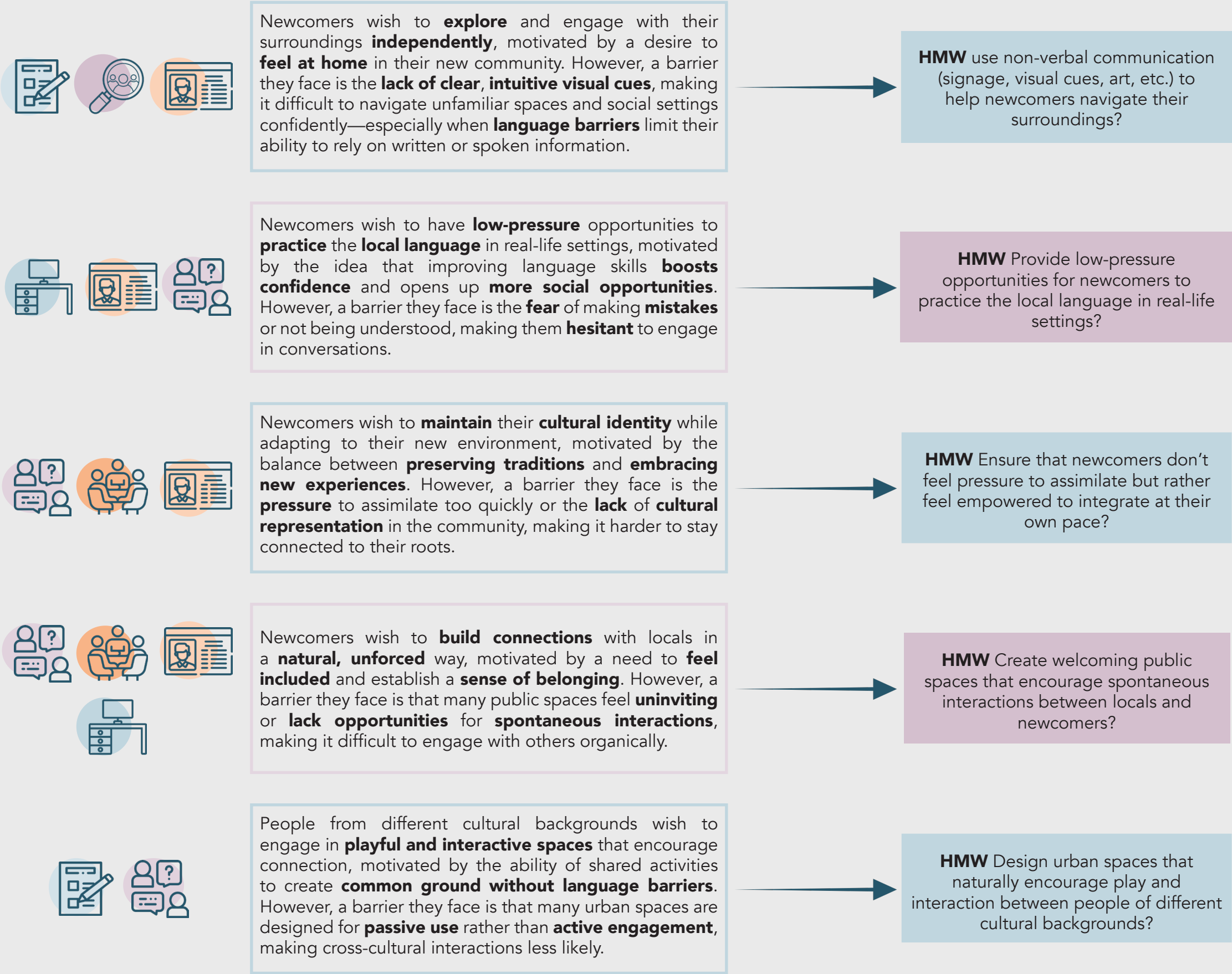
While initially considering Attentive Amir, we chose to focus on Sofia and Wei, as their needs align with **our goal of fostering spontaneous interactions**. Amir's priorities revolve around family-friendly spaces and structured engagement for his children.

Key Similarities:

- Desire for Spontaneous Interactions
 - Need for a Sense of Belonging
 - Challenges with Established Social Circles
 - Prefer Familiar, Inviting Spaces
- Creating **inviting, flexible** spaces that encourage **organic interactions** is key to helping newcomers feel a true **sense of belonging**.

Research Conclusion: Insights and Opportunities

-  Desk Research
-  Surveys
-  Observations
-  Interviews
-  Context Mapping
-  Personas and Journey mapping



Problem Statement

When newcomers move to a new city—especially **internationally**—they often face significant **social barriers** that lead to **culture shock** and isolation. Language barriers, unfamiliar customs, and a lack of natural social entry points make it **difficult to integrate** into their new community. Traditional methods of connection, such as structured events, can **feel overwhelming** or inaccessible, leaving newcomers **unsure** of how to engage.

- ### Steps we took to develop our HMW:

Reviewed all existing insights and HMW questions, identifying common themes.

Noticed recurring challenges, such as social barriers, language difficulties, and the need for low-pressure interactions.

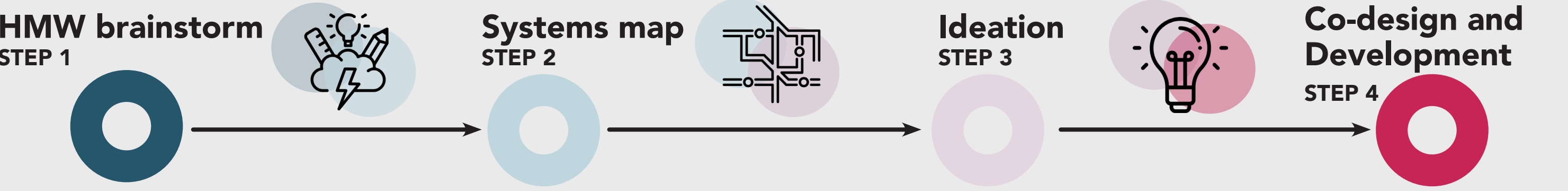
Combined overlapping ideas to narrow our focus on interactive, non-verbal elements.

Chose this direction as it provides an inclusive, accessible way to support newcomer integration.

HMW create interactive, non-verbal experiences in public spaces that help newcomers navigate cultural and social barriers at their own pace?

Ideation Overview

An overview of the journey from insights and our HMW to divergent ideas and areas for further development.



A brainstorm and initial conceptualisation around some key words in our HMW. A systems map to see connections that exist between people in a community. Using the brainstorm and systems map we generated some ideas to answer our HMW. Taking a few of our ideas we prototyped them and presented them to possible users.

- Aims & Approach:**

 - Generate some initial concepts from our HMW
 - 2 explorations each of a word related to the HMW
- Aims & Approach:**

 - Create a map of interactions and opportunities in a neighbourhood
 - Spot feedback loops and unexpected connections
- Aims & Approach:**

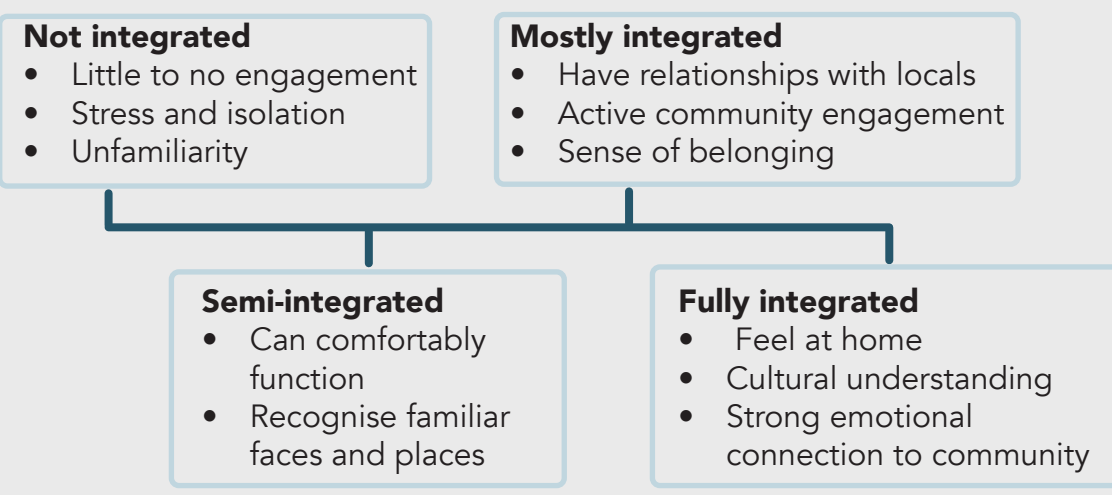
 - With HMW in mind generate ideas
 - Explore how play could alleviate cultural shock and bridge social barriers
- Aims & Approach:**

 - Get feedback on our ideas to see what works and what doesn't
 - Develop these ideas after the feedback

HMW brainstorm

HMW create interactive, non-verbal experiences in public spaces that help newcomers navigate cultural and social barriers at their own pace?

Spontaneous and **low-pressure** situations can be key in helping people integrate at their own pace. As part of our HMW exploration, we focused on these interactions to understand how **casual encounters** can **naturally develop** into **deeper connections**. This approach felt especially important for newcomers, as many **struggle with language barriers** and may feel **anxious about making mistakes**.



Spontaneous

Low pressure

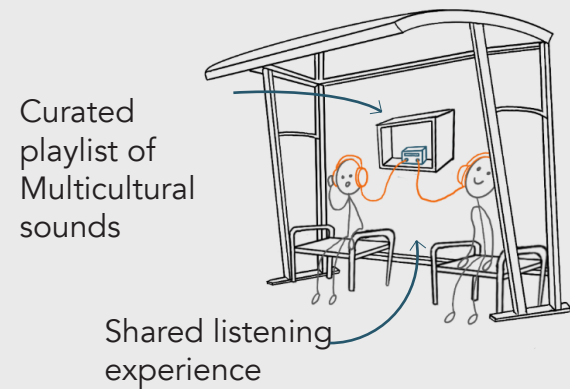
Interactivity

Non verbal

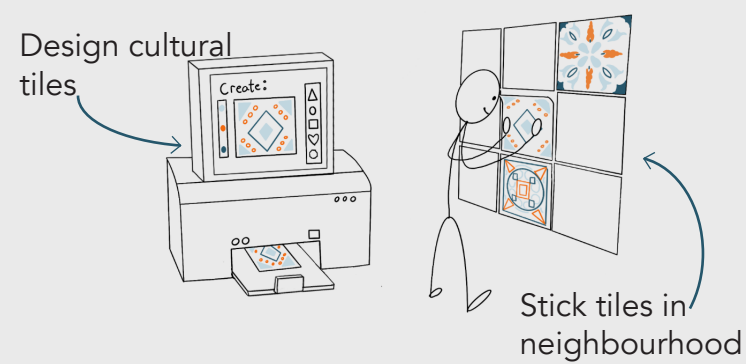
Ideas

Spontaneous
 Low pressure and spontaneous
 Low pressure
 Neither low pressure or spontaneous

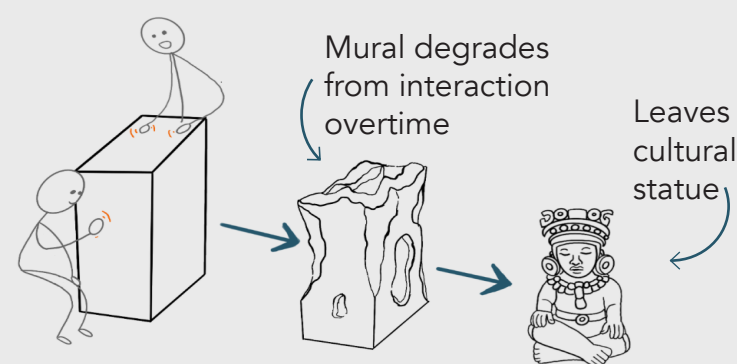
1 Shared Headphone Dock



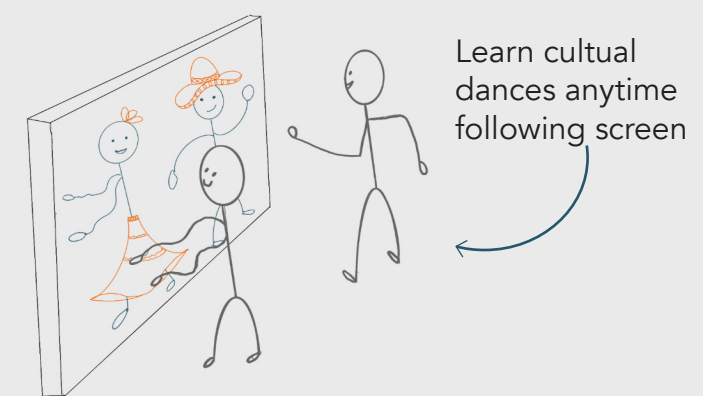
2 Printed Tiles



3 Interaction Revealing Mural



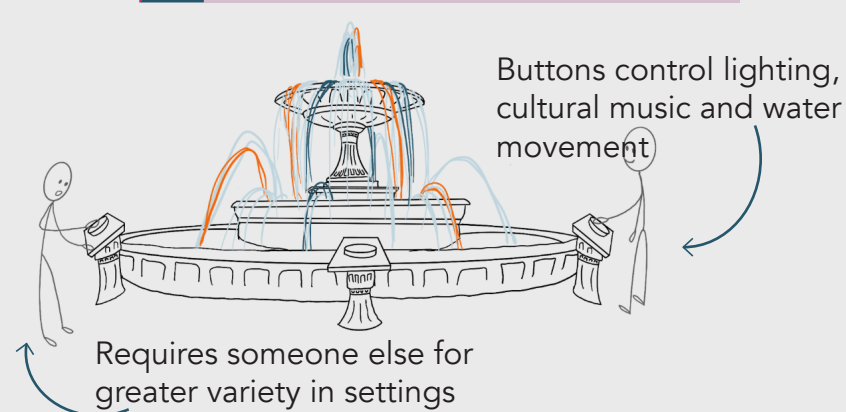
4 Cultural dance screen



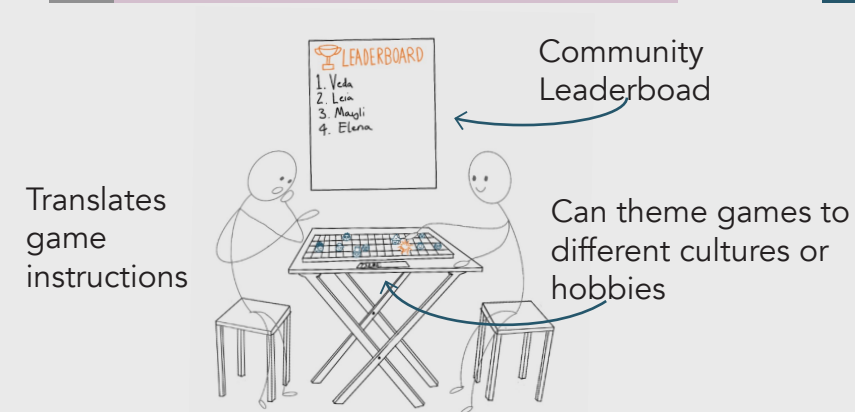
5 Language tiles



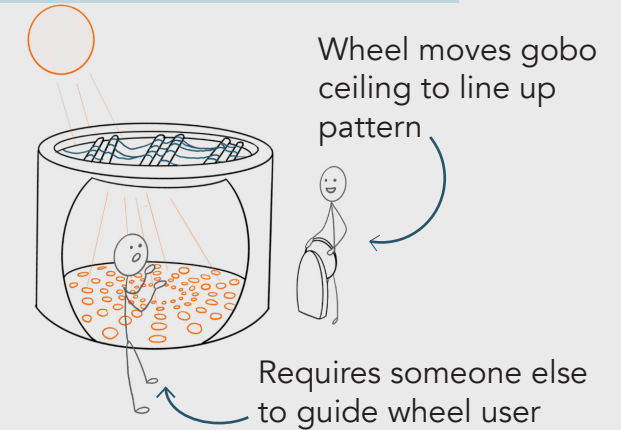
6 Button controlled Fountain



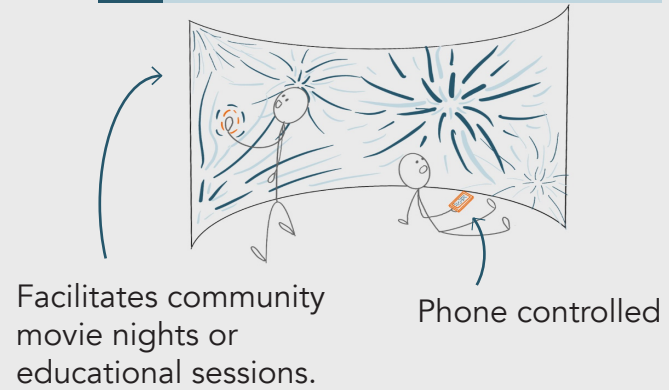
7 Virtual Themed Board Games



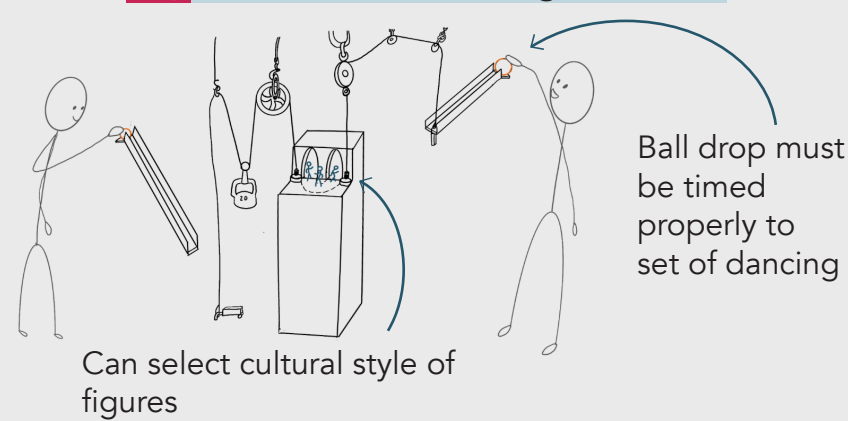
8 Wheel controlled Gobo



9 Interactive Screen



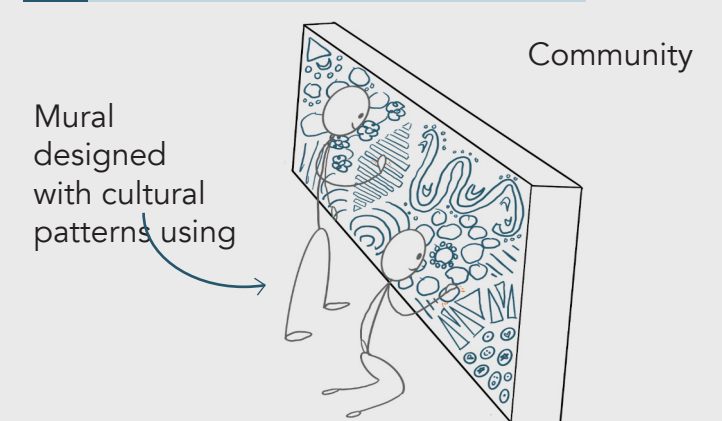
10 Duo Rube Goldberg machine



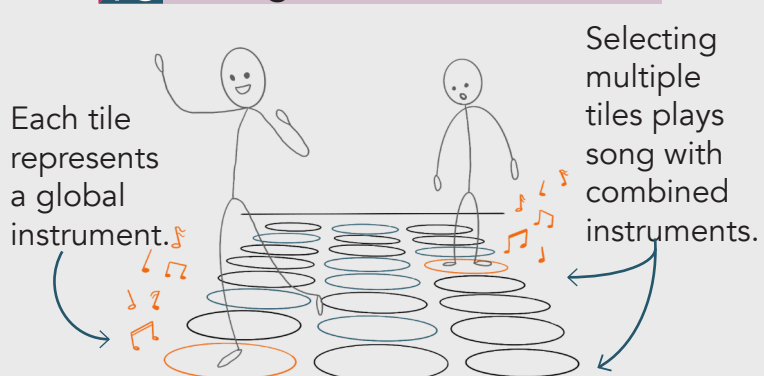
11 Community robotic Ducks



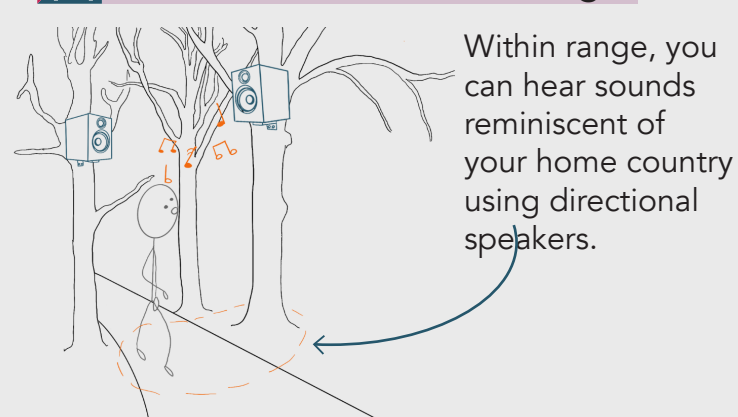
12 Two Team Mural



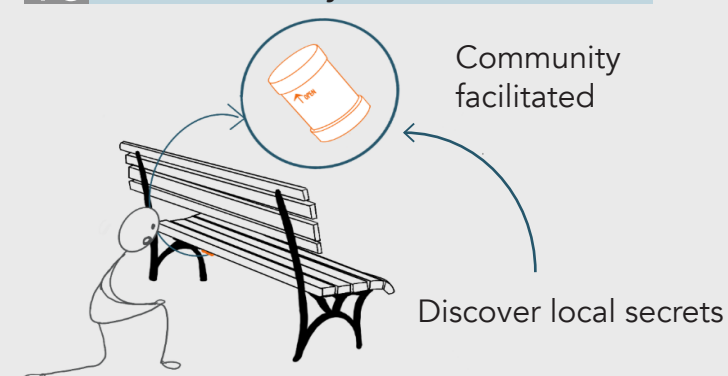
13 Song Combination floor



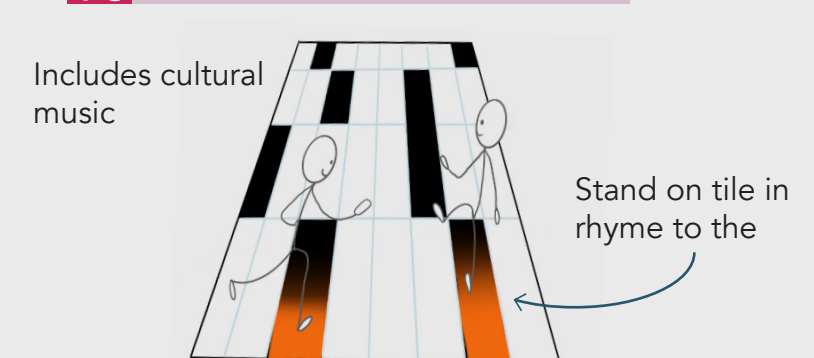
14 Cultural sounds within range



15 Community Treasure Hunt

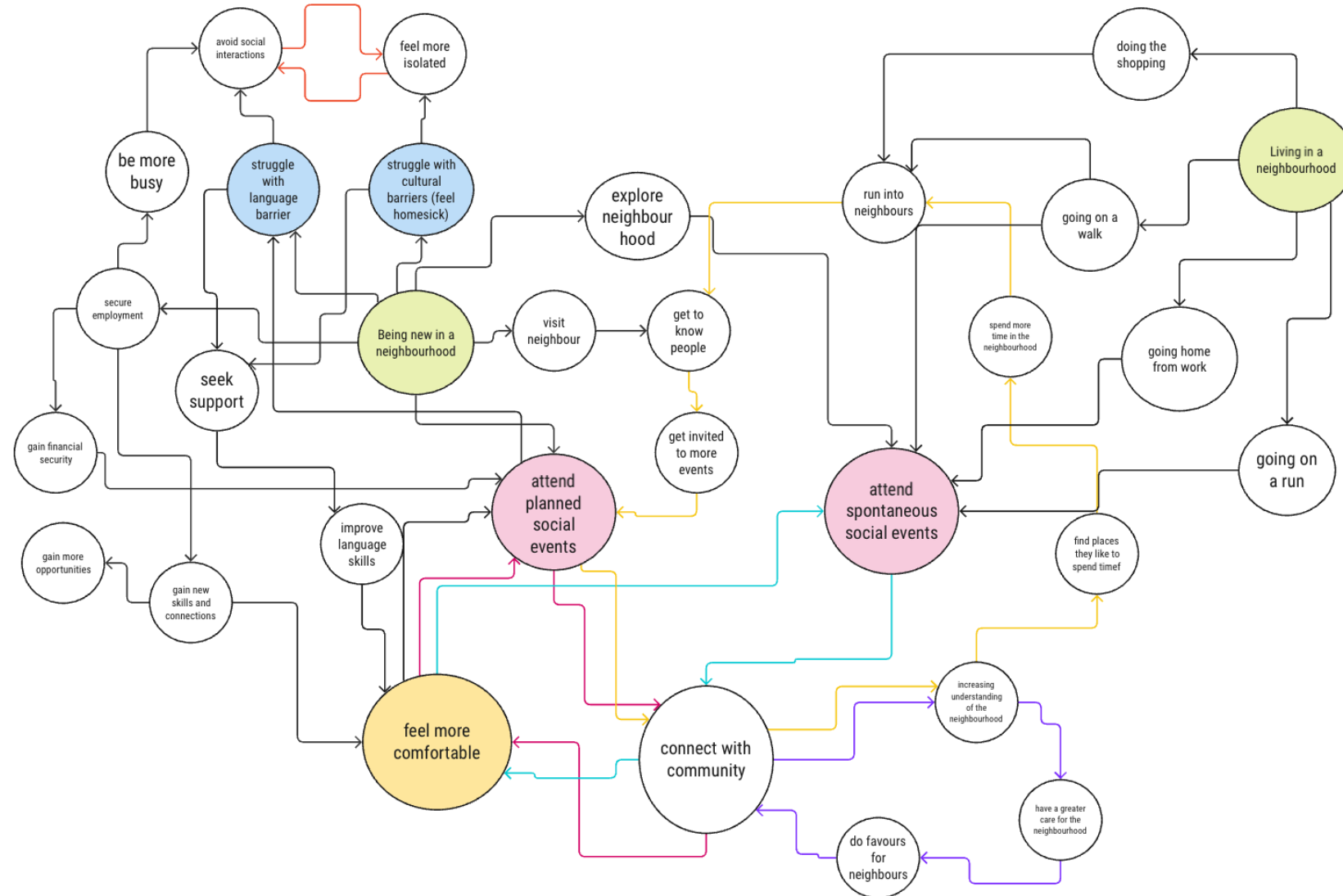


16 Piano Tiles



System mapping

Our systems map explores how newcomers navigate cultural and social barriers in a new community, focusing on behaviors in one neighborhood and the factors shaping their integration.



Feedback loops:



This is a loop we want to encourage, as it creates self-sufficiency.



Unplanned encounters ease integration without requiring deliberate effort, making it an accessible starting point for newcomers.



Giving favours strengthens community, creating a positive chain reaction that increases overall member satisfaction.



Being proactive in the community has an increased benefit on the member.



This negative loop is something we want to prevent or provide an escape to break out of.

While making the systems map, it was not originally going to have loops, but as the connecting went on, the loops naturally developed, they weren't forced.



Starting points of system



'Feel more comfortable' is a connecting point: enables movement between the positive loops.



Key decision points that determines entry into either a positive or negative cycle.



Public Spaces as a Bottleneck; A lack of shared spaces limits both planned and spontaneous social interactions, restricting positive feedback loops.

Considerations for ideation based on systems mapping:

- Design for **comfort** of user and **approachability**
- Try and enable some **natural, unplanned** connections
- Encourage **self-navigation**, so that people don't feel forced to explore the area
- Promote a sense of **community**, to make everyone feel **integrated**
- Support the integration by carrying it in **small and gradual steps**
- How people react to **cultural barriers** will impact future **satisfaction** within community

Co-design and Prototypes

Development
of ideas



	1 Shared Headphone Dock	2 Printed Tiles	3 Interaction Revealing Mural	4 Cultural dance screen	5 Language Tiles	6 Button Controlled fountain	7 Virtual themed board game	8 Wheel control Gobo	9 Interactive screen	10 Goldbergeg machine	11 Community robotic Ducks	12 Team mural	13 Instrument Combination floor	14 Cultural sounds within range	15 Community treasure Hunt	16 Piano tiles
Interactive	7	8	9	8.5	8.5	9	9.5	8.5	5.5	8.5	8.5	8.5	9	2.5	5	9
Non-Verbal	8.5	9	7.5	8	4.5	7.5	6.5	4	8	3.5	4.5	7	8.5	8.5	7	8.5
Help overcome Cultural barriers	3.5	6	3	6	7	4	5.5	2.5	7.5	2.5	5.5	3.5	8	9	2.5	7
Help overcome Social barriers	5.5	5	4.5	6.5	3	8	5.5	6.5	4.5	5	3.5	6.5	7	8.5	3	8.5
Total	24.5	28	24	29	23	28.5	27	21.5	25.5	19.5	22	25.5	32.5	28.5	17.5	33

Co-Design Table Process:

To ensure our solutions effectively addressed the needs of **migrants aged 20-35**, we conducted a **co-design session** with five individuals from our target user group. Participants ranked our ideas on a **scale of 1-10** based on four key criteria:

- Interactiveness** – How engaging and immersive the idea was in creating an interactive experience.
- Non-verbal Accessibility** – Whether users could engage without needing to speak or understand English.
- Effectiveness in Overcoming Social Barriers** – How well the idea facilitated social connection.
- Effectiveness in Overcoming Cultural Barriers** – Whether the idea helped bridge cultural differences.

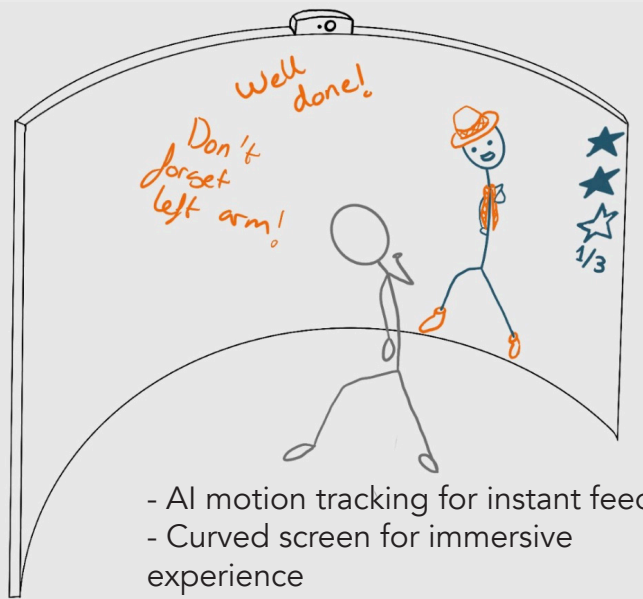


We **calculated the average scores** and total rankings to identify the **most feasible and impactful concepts** for further development. However, we recognized that **cultural barriers naturally ranked lower**, as they are complex and require multiple **small changes over time** rather than a single solution.

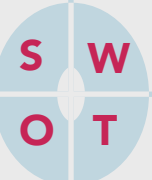
Additionally, we observed that participants tended to put less thought into their rankings as they progressed through the list. To counteract this, we asked the last two participants to rank ideas in reverse order (last to first) **to encourage more considered responses**.

To aid understanding, we provided participants with **rough prototypes or sketches** of our more complex ideas, allowing them to give **informed feedback**. This process **helped us refine our designs** to ensure they were **both practical and meaningful** for the people they aimed to support.

1 Cultural dance screen



Engaging
Scalable and adaptable
Cultural Exchange

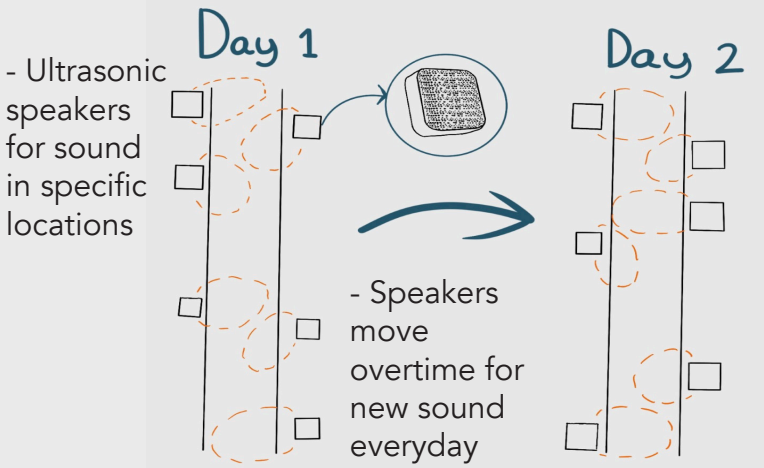


Accessibility Concerns
Weather Limitations
Space Limitations

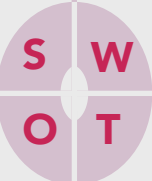
Customisable Content
Alternative Activations
Community Engagement

Technical Glitches
User Learning curve
Vandalism and Wear

2 Cultural sounds walk



Cultural Exchange
Immersive Experience
Customisable



Weather Limitations
Potentially repetitive
Space Restrictions

Cultural themes
App connection
Integration with local events

Technical Glitches
Noise Complaints
Vandalism and Wear

Codesign and Development

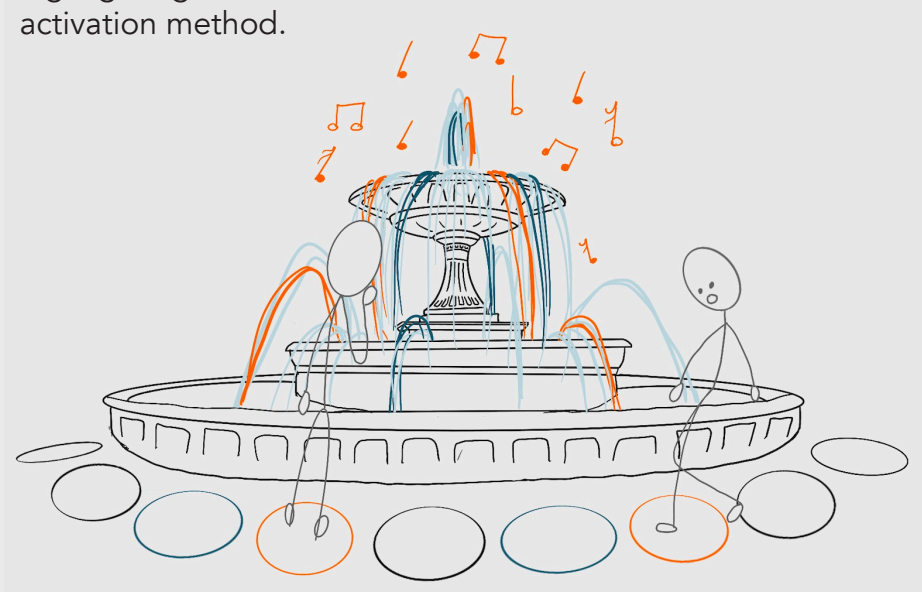
This page presents the codesign process for three refined ideas, focusing on interactivity, accessibility, and cultural inclusivity. A SWOT analysis (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, and Threats) highlights key improvements.

3 Music Button Fountain

We **combined** the **Button-Controlled Fountain** with the **Instrument Combination Floor** to enhance **cultural inclusivity**. While the fountain ranked lower in overcoming cultural barriers, integrating cultural music from the instrument tiles **strengthened the design**, creating a more immersive and engaging experience.

We **prototyped** the fountain and instrument tiles using a cup as a placeholder for the fountain and 3D-printed round tiles with different instruments. This **helped participants quickly grasp the concept**. Participants arranged the tiles in two distinct ways (as seen in the photos) which is worth considering in future iterations.

Testing elevated music tiles as buttons **revealed accessibility concerns** - wheelchair users may struggle to step on them, highlighting the need for an alternative activation method.

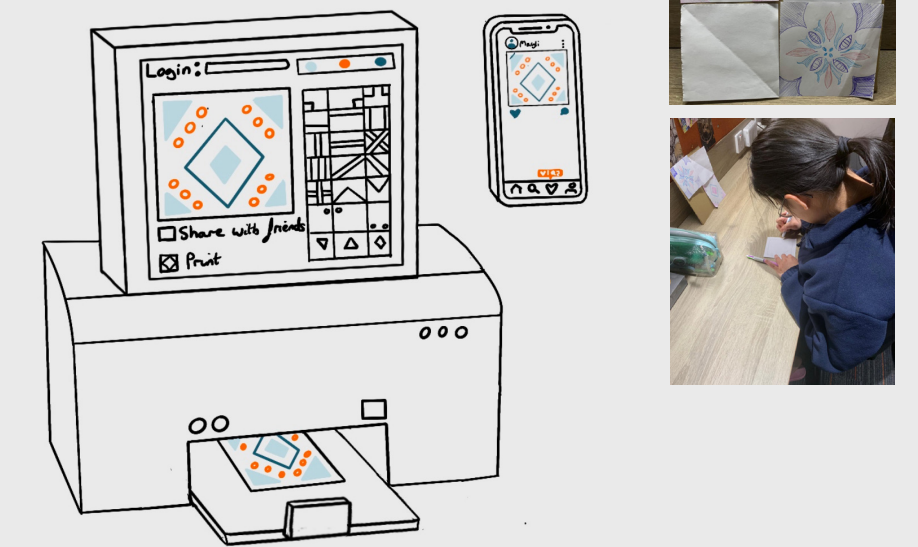


Interactive & Engaging	Potential	Weather	Limitations
Cultural Inclusivity	S W O T	Accessibility Issues	Complex Installation
Encourages Collaboration		Vandalism	Wear and tear
Scalability		Noise Complaints	
Community Engagement			
Adaptable Activation Methods			

4 Printable Sticker Tiles

Users design and print **cultural tiles** using preset templates, ensuring creativity while preventing inappropriate content. Tiles can be **placed around the neighborhood** and saved in an interactive app, where people can **collect, share, and engage** through likes and comments - **blending physical and digital community interaction**.

Our participant loved the idea of **revisiting her designs**, saying it would make neighborhood walks **more engaging** - reminding her of an activity she enjoyed as a child. The ability to **search for existing tiles** added a sense of connection, making public spaces feel **more personal and interactive**. The app feature was well received, as it extends the experience beyond physical tiles, allowing for continued engagement through **virtual interaction with others**.

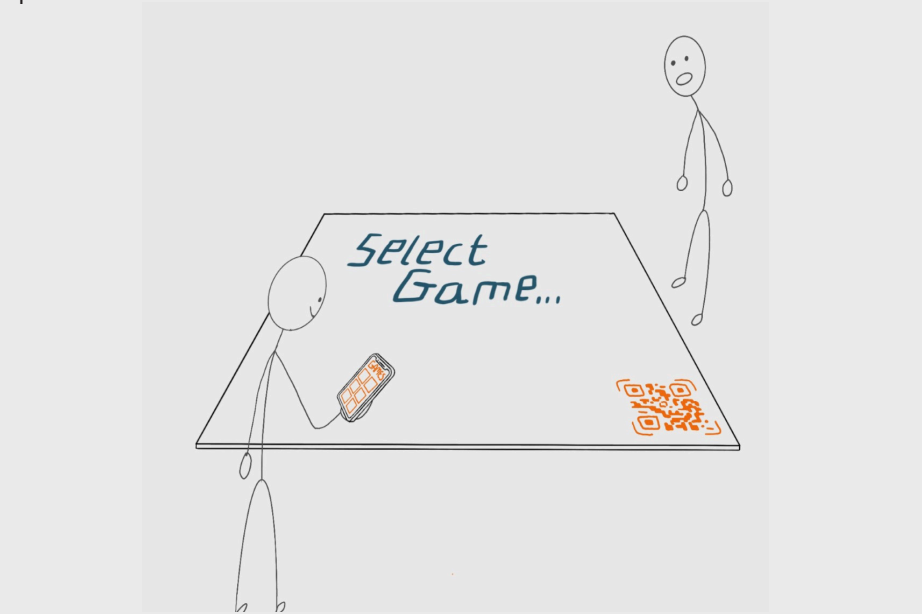


Community Engagement	Limited Customization
Low-Barrier Creativity	Sticker Durability
Interactive & Personal	Weather Limitation
S W O T	Technical issues
	Glitches
App Features	Vandalism and misuse
Local Events	
Enhanced Printing Options	

5 Large Floor Game Screen

The Virtual Themed Board Game was the most interactive idea but **ranked lower in overcoming cultural and social barriers**. To strengthen it, we **combined** it with Piano Tiles, which featured cultural music, making the concept **more culturally inclusive**. We also expanded gameplay options, introducing multiple **life-sized games like Ludo**, making the experience more varied, engaging, and socially interactive.

Participants appreciated the **interactive and engaging** nature of the Virtual Themed Board Game but found **it lacked strong cultural and social integration**. Prototyping highlighted the potential for more varied gameplay, leading to the addition of multiple life-sized games like Ludo to encourage **greater participation**. We learned that **incorporating cultural elements**, such as music from Piano Tiles, made the game more inclusive, enhancing both engagement and cultural representation.



Interactive & Engaging	Requires the use of Technology
Flexible and Adaptable	Space Requirement
Lots of options	Accessability Issues
S W O T	Weather & Durability
	Technical Barriers
Alternative Game Modes	Engagement
Community Events	
Cultural Themes	

Appendix

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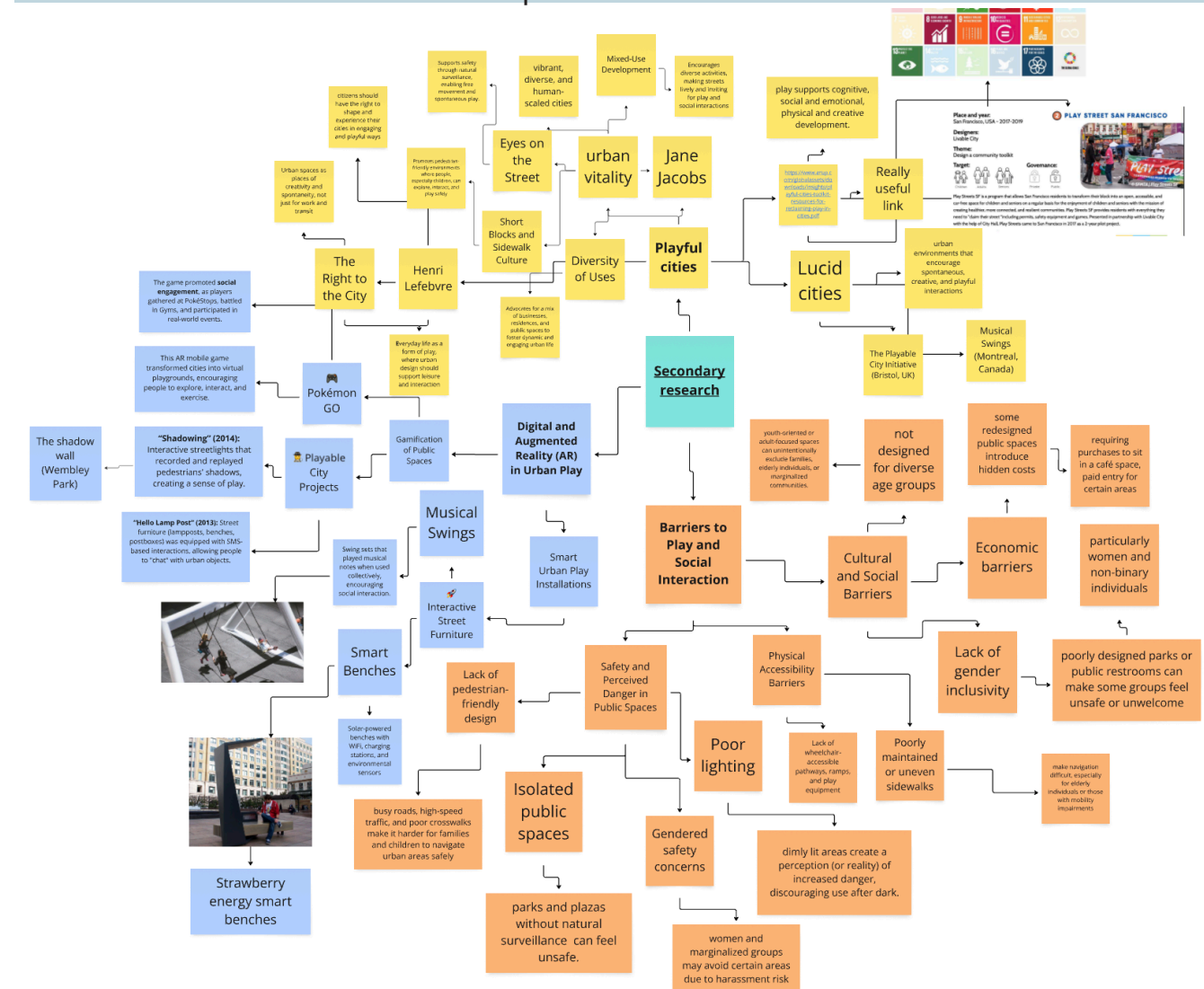
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Mindmap of initial research



Mood Board and Inspo pictures



More Survey Results

